

STILL ME

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A life-story book, filled in together.

JOSHUA CALEB GREEN

WORDS TO KEEP

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No part of the printed text of this book may be reproduced without permission from the publisher. Everything written into this book by hand belongs to the person it is about, and to the people who care for them.

This book is not a medical document and does not replace the advice of the people treating the person it is about. Where it describes what helps, it describes what families and care staff have found helpful, and nothing more.

Series: Words to Keep

If you're giving this book

Five things that make the difference between a book that gets used and one that stays in a drawer.

1. Fill in the next page before you give it. Write who it's for and who's filling it in. A book with a name on it gets opened.
2. Read Part One yourself first. It's short, and it will change how the first visit goes.
3. Do the two-minute page in the second half before anything else. It's useful on day one.
4. Bring three photographs to the first visit. The book explains why.
5. Tell whoever else cares for them that the book exists, and where it lives.

This book is for

Filled in by

Started on

Kept at

Before you start

The person this book is about is still here. Some of what they know is going, and it's going in an order nobody chose: this morning first, and 1961 last. This book goes where the memory is strongest, and it writes down what it finds there, in their words, while they can still say them.

It has two halves. The first is the story of who they are, told to you, one page at a time, at the kitchen table or the bedside. The second is for whoever cares for them: what calms them, what upsets them, what they eat, what to say when they ask for someone who isn't coming.

Nothing in it has to be finished. A page with three words on it is a good page. A page left blank is an honest one.

Before you sit down with them, read the part called How to do this. It's fourteen pages, and it will make the first visit go better than it otherwise would. Then bring three photographs and a pen, and start with the house they grew up in.

PART ONE

How to do this

What this book is, and what it isn't

This is a book about one person. It is written by them, as much as they can, and by the people who love them, for the rest. It has two halves. The first tells the story of who they are: where they came from, who mattered, what they did, what they're proud of, what makes them laugh. The second tells the people who care for them how to do it well: what calms them, what upsets them, what they eat, what to say when they ask for someone who isn't coming.

It is not a medical record. It is not a test of anyone's memory. It is not something to finish. A page with three words on it is a good page.

It is also not a goodbye. The title is the point. The person in this book is still here, and this book is one of the ways the people around them can keep seeing that.

Why a life story matters now

When memory starts to go, it doesn't go all at once, and it doesn't go in order. What happened this morning goes first. What happened in 1961 often stays for years. A person who can't tell you what they had for breakfast can tell you the name of the dog they had when they were nine, and the street it ran away down, and what their mother said when it came back.

That is not a small thing. It's where they live now, more and more. A life-story book goes there with them.

Care homes and hospitals have used books like this for a long time, and for practical reasons. A nurse on a night shift who knows that a frightened man was a fisherman for forty years can talk to him about boats, and he settles. A carer who knows that a woman hates having her hair touched, because of something that happened in a school in 1950, can wash her hair a different way. Staff change. Shifts change. The book doesn't.

For the family, it does something else. It makes the visits easier. There is something to do together. There is something to talk about that isn't the illness, and the person gets to be the expert in the room, because nobody knows their life better than they do.

Who does the writing

The person, when they can. You, when they can't. Both, most of the time.

Early on, many people can and want to write for themselves. Let them, even if the handwriting has changed, even if it takes a long time. Their hand on the page is worth more than your neat one.

When writing gets hard, they talk and you write. Write what they say, the way they say it. Don't tidy it. "We had a dog, a big daft thing, ran off every chance it got" is better than "The family owned a dog." If they say it in their first language, write it in that language and ask someone to translate underneath.

When talking gets hard, you write what you know, and you say so at the top of the page: "Written by Anna, from what Mum told me over the years." That's still their story. It's just being carried.

When to sit down, and for how long

Most people have a good part of the day. Often it's the morning, after breakfast, before they're tired. Sometimes it's the afternoon. You know, or you'll learn. Sit down then.

Twenty minutes is plenty. Ten is fine. Stop before they're tired, not when. If you stop while it's still good, they'll want to do it again. If you push to the end of a page and they get frustrated, the book becomes a chore, and it will stay on the shelf.

One page a visit is a good pace. One page a week fills the book in a year. There is no deadline. The book is patient.

Sit beside them, not across from them. Put the book between you so you can both see it. Don't hold a pen over it like a form. Have a cup of tea. Have the photographs out.

A first visit, start to finish

Say it's a Tuesday morning. You've brought the book, a pen, and three photographs: the house, the wedding, and one of them at about twenty.

You don't start with the book. You start with the photograph of the house, put down on the table without a word. Wait. Most people pick it up. "That's Elm Street." Now you have a place to begin.

"Tell me about Elm Street." Let them. When they stop, say something they said back to them, and wait again. When they've said what they're going to say, open the book to the page called The house I grew up in, and say, "I'm going to write that down, the way you said it." Write it. Read it back. Ask if that's right. If they change it, change it.

That's the visit. Fifteen minutes, one page, one photograph. Put the photograph in the box on the page if there's room, or paper-clip it in. Close the book. Have the tea.

The second visit starts with the second photograph. By the third or fourth, you'll find they ask for the book.

How to ask

Ask about long ago before you ask about last week. Long ago is where the memory is strongest, and it's also where the best stories are.

Ask one thing at a time. "Tell me about the house on Elm Street" works. "Tell me about your childhood" doesn't, because it's too big, and a person who can't find the way in feels the not-finding.

Ask for pictures, not dates. "What could you see from your bedroom window?" opens a door. "What year did you move?" closes one, because the year is exactly the kind of fact that goes.

Follow the thread that lights up. If you ask about school and they start talking about the boy who sat behind them, let them. The boy is the story. School was just the way in.

Don't test. Never say "do you remember?" as a question they can fail. Say "I remember you telling me about." Say "your mother used to say." Give them the beginning and let them finish it.

Let silence be. Some answers take a minute to arrive. If you fill the silence, they stop looking for the answer.

Say their words back to them. "So the dog ran off down the hill." It tells them you're listening, and it often brings the next piece.

Questions that work, and why

Some questions open a door and some close one. The difference is usually whether the question asks for a fact or a picture. Facts go. Pictures stay.

Questions that tend to work:

- What could you see from the window of the house you grew up in?
- What did your mother call you when you were in trouble?
- What did the kitchen smell like on a Sunday?
- Who was the best-looking boy or girl in your class, and did they know it?
- What was the first thing you bought with your own money?
- What did your father do with his hands?
- Where did you go dancing?
- What did you sing when you thought nobody was listening?
- Tell me about the dog.

Questions that tend not to work, and why:

- "What year did you get married?" A date, and dates go first.
- "Do you remember your teacher's name?" A test with a fail.
- "What was your childhood like?" Too big to find the way in.

- "Why did you leave the farm?" Reasons are harder than pictures, and "why" can sound like an accusation.

If a question doesn't land, don't repeat it louder. Try a picture instead. Or try a photograph. Or leave it, and come back another day, when it may land for no reason anyone can see.

The questions in the second part of this book were chosen this way. Each one asks for a picture.

When the answer is wrong

It will be, sometimes. They'll put the wedding in the wrong town or give their brother their cousin's name, or tell you a story that you know happened to somebody else.

Write it down.

You're not keeping records. You're keeping them company. A wrong answer, corrected, teaches a person that they're failing at something in front of someone they love. A wrong answer, written down, is a story they told you on a Tuesday afternoon while the sun was on the table. If it matters, put the other version in the margin in small letters. Most of the time it won't matter.

Sometimes the answer will change from one visit to the next. Write both. Date them if you like. The book is allowed to disagree with itself. So are people.

When the answer hurts

Some questions will reach something painful. A child who died. A war. A first husband nobody mentions. A house that was lost.

You'll usually see it coming: a change in the face, a hand that goes still. When you do, you have two choices, and both are right. You can go there gently, if they want to, and write what they say. Or you can turn the page. "Let's leave that one." Nothing in this book is required. That's printed on the pages, and it's meant.

If something surfaces that they've never told anyone, hold it. Don't react more than they do. Write it if they want it written. Let them decide what stays.

If a memory is frightening to them right now, in the present, don't try to reason it away. A person who is afraid because they think they have to get home to the children is not helped by being told the children are fifty years old. They're helped by being told the children are safe, and by a hand, and by a change of subject toward something they love. This is one of the hardest parts of caring for someone whose memory is going, and there is more about it in the section on the names to say.

Photographs, music, and things

Memory doesn't only live in words. Put a photograph on the table and the story comes out of it. Play a song from when they were seventeen and watch what happens to their face.

This book has boxes for photographs on many pages. Use them. Photographs of people, but also of places: the street, the shop, the church, the factory. A photograph of a house they lived in for thirty years will do more than any question.

Objects work the same way. A watch. A tool. A tin that always held buttons. Bring them. Put them in their hands. Ask nothing at first.

Music has its own section in the second half of this book, because staff will use it. Write the songs down with the names of who sang them. "The Sinatra one" won't help a twenty-two-year-old care worker at two in the morning. "Fly Me to the Moon, Frank Sinatra" will.

Writing it down: whose words

Write in the first person. "I was born in" and "my mother was," even when you're holding the pen. The book is theirs. When you add something of your own, mark it: your initials, or "Anna adds." Keep the two voices separate on the page, so that years from now nobody has to guess.

Write large. Their eyes may be tired, and so will yours.

Don't fix the grammar. Don't fix the spelling. Don't fix the story.

If they use a word for something that nobody outside the family uses, write the word, and put what it means in brackets. There's a page for these in the second half, because

carers need them too. A woman who asks for "the wee cloth" every night and doesn't get it is not a difficult woman. She's a woman nobody translated for.

The second half of this book

Everything from the page marked What helps onward is written for the people who care for the person: family, home carers, staff in a care home, hospital staff, a hospice team. It's practical. It's the part that gets read at a shift change.

Fill it in as a family, and update it. What calms someone in March may not calm them in November. The pages have room for dates and for crossing out. The log at the back is for what changed, when, and what you did about it.

Fill it in even if the person is still at home and nobody else is caring for them yet. There will be a night when you're in hospital with them and a stranger asks you what they eat, and you'll be too tired to think. And there may be a day when someone else has to know all of this, and you're not there to say it.

Using the book with care staff

If the person moves into a care home, or has carers coming to the house, the book goes with them. Tell the staff it exists. Show them the two-minute page. Ask that it be kept where the person can see it, not in a file.

Good staff will use it without being asked. They'll read it on quiet nights. They'll notice the photograph of the fishing boat and start a conversation with it. You can help by putting the key facts where they'll be found: the two-minute page at the front of the second half, and the names and photographs at the back.

Make a copy of the two-minute page and the names page. Keep one at home. Give one to the home. Put one in the hospital bag. It's the single most useful thing in this book for a person who will meet dozens of strangers who need to know how to be kind to them.

The two-minute page

It's the first page of What helps. Two pages, actually. It's the version of this whole book that someone can read standing up.

What to call them. Who they'll ask for. What settles them. What frightens them.
What they like to eat and drink, and what they won't. Glasses, hearing aids, teeth.
How they show pain, because many people stop being able to say it. Faith, if it
matters. The song. The one sentence to say when they're anxious.

Fill this page in first, before anything else in the second half, and keep it current.

The names to say

The person will ask for people. Their mother, most often, even at ninety. A husband
who has died. A child who lives abroad. A dog.

Families disagree about what to say, and so do professionals. Some believe you should
always tell the truth, gently. Some believe that telling a person their mother has been
dead for forty years, and watching them hear it for the first time again, is a cruelty
with no purpose. Most people who do this work land somewhere in the middle, and
where they land depends on the person: what they can hold, what comforts them,
what makes it worse.

This book doesn't decide for you. It asks you to decide as a family, write it down, and
give it to everyone who cares for them, so that the answer is the same on Tuesday as it
is on Thursday, and the same from the night nurse as from the daughter.

For each person they ask for, the page asks: who this is, whether they're living, and
what we've agreed to say. "Mum's at the shops, she'll be back later" is an answer some
families choose. "She's not here right now, but she loved you very much" is another.
"Tell me about her" is a third, and it's often the best one, because it turns the
question into a story.

Whatever you choose, choose it together, write it down, and don't leave the carers to
guess.

On the days they don't know you

They will come. Not always, and not all at once. A day when they look at you
politely and ask when the daughter is coming.

There is nothing to fix here, and nothing to say that will make it not have happened.
But there are things that help.

Don't ask "do you know who I am?" It's a test, and the failing of it is worse for them than for you. Say your name as you sit down. "It's Anna. I've brought the book." It gives them the fact without the exam.

Open the book. Read them a page they wrote, or that you wrote together. The story of the dog. The song. Their own words in their own hand. You may find that the person who didn't know you is, ten minutes into the story of the boat, talking to you as if they always have. That is what the book is for on days like this.

And if it doesn't work, sit with them anyway. They may not know who you are. They know that someone kind is here.

For the one holding the pen

You're grieving someone who is in the room. Nobody says this plainly enough. It's exhausting, and it's strange, and there is no card for it.

This book will ask things of you. It will bring up stories you didn't know, and some of them will be hard to hear. It will bring up stories you've heard a hundred times, and one day you'll realize you've heard one for the last time, and you won't have known it was the last.

Some things that are allowed: to skip a visit. To stop after five minutes. To cry in the car. To leave a page blank for a year. To be angry at a book. To let a sibling or a grandchild do some of the writing, because their visits are different and the stories they get are different. To find that you like this, and to feel guilty about that, and to stop feeling guilty, because the person likes it too.

The book is not a measure of how well you're doing this. It's just a place to put what you're keeping.

If they're in hospital

Hospital is where the second half of this book earns its keep. A ward is loud and bright and full of strangers, and a person whose memory is going can lose the thread of where they are within an hour of arriving.

Bring the book. Put the two-minute page where the nurses will see it, on the table, or ask that it be copied into the notes. Tell the nurse the one sentence that settles them.

Tell them what the person will ask for. Tell them how they show pain, because on a ward a person who can't say "it hurts" is a person who doesn't get the tablet.

If you can, leave a photograph of a familiar face by the bed with the name written large underneath. If you can't be there, ask a nurse to read them a page from the first half of the book. The story of the boat has calmed people in worse places than a ward.

If English isn't their first language

People often go back to their first language as memory goes, even after fifty years of speaking another. If that's happening, or may happen, write the second half of this book in both languages: the sentence that settles them, the words for food and drink and the toilet, the names. A carer who can say "it's all right" in Polish or Tagalog or Spanish, badly, is giving that person something nobody else on the shift can.

Write the life story in whichever language it comes out in. Translate underneath, small, so the original stays theirs.

For the grandchildren

Children are often better at this than adults. They don't correct. They don't mind the same story twice. They ask the questions adults are too polite to ask, and they get answers adults don't.

Give a grandchild a job. The photographs are a good one: finding them, choosing them, writing the names underneath. The drawings are another. The quick questions at the end of the first half are made for a ten-year-old with a pen and a grandparent with an afternoon.

If the person doesn't recognize the child, tell the child before it happens, in plain words: "Grandma's memory is going, and some days she may not know your name. She still likes you. Say your name when you come in, and don't ask her to guess." Children manage this better than we expect, when they're told the truth.

Common worries

She gets upset when we talk about the past. Then don't go there today. Some people find the past painful and the present easier, and the second half of this book matters more for them than the first. Come back to the stories through something sideways: music, a recipe, a photograph of a place rather than a person.

He says he doesn't want to. Then he doesn't have to. Leave the book on the table where he can see it. Fill in a page of the second half in front of him, out loud: "I'm writing that you like your tea strong." He may correct you. That's the start.

The family disagrees about what to write. Write both. The book has margins. Where it's about care, the names to say, the food, the faith, decide together and write one answer, because carers need one answer. Where it's about the story, two versions is a richer story.

She can't write anymore. Then she talks and you write, and the page says so. Her voice in your hand is still her voice.

Is it too late? Almost never. A person who can't answer a question can often still respond to a photograph, a song, a smell, a name. Fill in the second half from what you know. Read the first half aloud from what you remember. The book is for them either way.

I don't know most of this. Nobody does. Ask the siblings, the cousins, the neighbor who's known them fifty years. Fill in what you can, and leave the rest. A page with a question and no answer is an honest page.

What to do with this book later

Later, this book becomes something else. It becomes the story of a person, told in their own words and their family's, from the time when it could still be told. The wrong towns and the changing answers will be part of it. So will the handwriting, and the way it changed.

Keep it. Copy the two-minute page for the next stranger who needs it. And when the time comes that the second half isn't needed anymore, the first half will still be here, and it will still be them.

For a photograph, a drawing, or anything else.

PART TWO

This is me

My story, in my own words where I can give them, and in the words of the people who love me where I can't.

One question to a page. Long ago first. Photographs wherever they'll fit.

My name, and what people call me.

The name on the certificate, the name my mother used, and the name my friends used. They may all be different.

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A PHOTOGRAPH, IF THERE IS ONE

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

My mother.

What she was like. What she called me. What she'd say if she walked in now.

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A PHOTOGRAPH, IF THERE IS ONE

My father.

What he did with his hands. What he did on a Sunday.

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A PHOTOGRAPH, IF THERE IS ONE

The house I grew up in.

What I could see from the window. What the kitchen smelled like.

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School.

The teacher. The friend. The trouble.

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My first job.

What I got paid, and what I did with it.

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A PHOTOGRAPH, IF THERE IS ONE

The work I did for most of my life.

What I actually did all day.

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A PHOTOGRAPH, IF THERE IS ONE

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The person I built a life with.

How we met. What I noticed first.

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My children.

One at a time. What they were like small.

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My friends.

The oldest one. The funniest one.

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The music I loved.

The songs, and who sang them.

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What I did on a Sunday.

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A PHOTOGRAPH, IF THERE IS ONE

Things I believed in.

Faith, if it mattered. Rules I lived by. What I'd defend.

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The times I lived through.

The war, the strike, the flood, the year everything changed. What I saw of it.

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A PHOTOGRAPH, IF THERE IS ONE

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My first love.

Only if I want to.

[illegible]

A PHOTOGRAPH, IF THERE IS ONE

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Quick ones

The name of my first dog.

My mother's first name.

The street I grew up on.

The year I left school. A guess is fine.

My team.

My favorite sweet thing.

A question from your family.

Written by the person who gave you this book.

THEIR QUESTION

[illegible]

For a photograph, a drawing, or anything else.

PART THREE

What helps

For anyone who looks after me: my family, carers at home, staff in a care home or a hospital.

Start with the two-minute page. Keep it current. Copy it for anyone new. Everything after it is the long version.

The two-minute page

Read this first. It's the whole book, standing up.

CALL ME

I'LL ASK FOR

WHAT SETTLES ME

WHAT FRIGHTENS OR UPSETS ME

I LIKE TO EAT

I LIKE TO DRINK, AND HOW

I WON'T

GLASSES, HEARING AIDS, TEETH

The two-minute page, continued

HOW I SHOW PAIN

FAITH, AND WHAT MATTERS ABOUT IT

THE SONG

THE SENTENCE TO SAY WHEN I'M ANXIOUS

THINGS I CAN DO FOR MYSELF

THINGS I NEED HELP WITH

WHO TO CALL, AND WHEN

My day

The shape of a good day. Times if they matter.

MORNING

MEALS

AFTERNOON

EVENING

NIGHT

What calms me

WHAT HAS WORKED

WHAT HASN'T

WHAT TO TRY WHEN NOTHING WORKS

What upsets me, and how to tell

THINGS THAT UPSET ME

HOW YOU'LL KNOW

WHAT TO DO

The names to say

I'll ask for people. For each one: who they are, whether they're living, and what we've agreed to say. Decide it together. Give everyone the same answer.

NAME

WHO THEY ARE TO ME

LIVING, OR NOT, AND WHERE

WHAT WE HAVE AGREED TO SAY

NAME

WHO THEY ARE TO ME

LIVING, OR NOT, AND WHERE

WHAT WE HAVE AGREED TO SAY

NAME

WHO THEY ARE TO ME

LIVING, OR NOT, AND WHERE

WHAT WE HAVE AGREED TO SAY

The names to say, continued

NAME	WHO THEY ARE TO ME
LIVING, OR NOT, AND WHERE	
WHAT WE HAVE AGREED TO SAY	

NAME	WHO THEY ARE TO ME
LIVING, OR NOT, AND WHERE	
WHAT WE HAVE AGREED TO SAY	

NAME	WHO THEY ARE TO ME
LIVING, OR NOT, AND WHERE	
WHAT WE HAVE AGREED TO SAY	

Food and drink

BREAKFAST

WHAT I ALWAYS LIKE

WHAT I WON'T EAT

HOW I TAKE MY TEA OR COFFEE

HELP I NEED WITH EATING

SWALLOWING, DIET, OR ALLERGY NOTES

Music

Names of songs and who sang them. "The Sinatra one" won't help at two in the morning.

SONGS

HYMNS, ANTHEMS, OR SONGS FROM HOME

MUSIC THAT UPSETS ME

THE ONE TO PLAY WHEN NOTHING ELSE WORKS

Things I can still do, and like to do

THINGS I CAN DO ON MY OWN

THINGS I CAN DO WITH A LITTLE HELP

THINGS I'VE ALWAYS LIKED DOING

[illegible]

How I like to be helped

Dignity is in the details.

WASHING

DRESSING

HAIR

THE TOILET

MOVING ABOUT

THINGS I'D RATHER DO MYSELF, EVEN SLOWLY

Words we use

Family words for things. A carer who doesn't know them can't help.

THE WORD	WHAT IT MEANS
THE WORD	WHAT IT MEANS
THE WORD	WHAT IT MEANS
THE WORD	WHAT IT MEANS
THE WORD	WHAT IT MEANS
THE WORD	WHAT IT MEANS
THE WORD	WHAT IT MEANS

What I was like before

So that whoever reads this sees the person, not the illness.

IN THREE WORDS, FROM SOMEONE WHO'S KNOWN ME A LONG TIME

WHAT I DID FOR A LIVING, AND WHAT I WAS LIKE AT IT

WHAT I WAS KNOWN FOR

WHAT I'D BE DOING RIGHT NOW, IF I COULD

On a bad day

WHAT A BAD DAY LOOKS LIKE

WHAT HAS HELPED

WHAT MAKES IT WORSE

WHO TO CALL

Sleep

BEDTIME, AND WHAT HELPS

NIGHT WAKING, AND WHAT TO DO

MORNING

Pain and discomfort

Many people stop being able to say it hurts. Write how I show it.

HOW I SHOW PAIN

WHERE IT USUALLY IS

WHAT HELPS

WHAT I CAN'T TELL YOU, THAT YOU SHOULD CHECK

Visitors, and what to do together

For anyone who comes. Twenty minutes with a plan is better than an hour without one.

WHO VISITS, AND WHEN

THINGS WE CAN DO TOGETHER THAT WORK

THINGS THAT DON'T

PLACES WE CAN GO

Pages to read aloud

The pages from the first half that land best. Write the page number and a word about why.

PAGES THAT MAKE ME SMILE

PAGES THAT SETTLE ME

PAGES TO AVOID ON A BAD DAY

People

NAME

WHO, OR WHERE

NAME

WHO, OR WHERE

NAME

WHO, OR WHERE

NAME

WHO, OR WHERE

People, continued

NAME

WHO, OR WHERE

NAME

WHO, OR WHERE

NAME

WHO, OR WHERE

NAME

WHO, OR WHERE

Places and things

NAME

WHO, OR WHERE

NAME

WHO, OR WHERE

NAME

WHO, OR WHERE

NAME

WHO, OR WHERE

Places and things, continued

NAME

WHO, OR WHERE

NAME

WHO, OR WHERE

NAME

WHO, OR WHERE

NAME

WHO, OR WHERE

What changed

Date. What changed. What we did about it.

DATE	WHAT CHANGED, AND WHAT WE DID
DATE	WHAT CHANGED, AND WHAT WE DID
DATE	WHAT CHANGED, AND WHAT WE DID
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What changed, continued

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For the one reading this

The person in this book told you who they are, while they could. The people who love them wrote down the rest. If you're caring for them and you've read this far, you know them better than most people ever will. Use it.

Anything else.

[illegible]

[illegible]

